

The Ivanpah solar plant in the Mojave Desert, California, generates enough concentrated solar power to serve more than 140,000 homes at peak hours of the day.

Renewables v. fossil fuels

Human civilizations have drawn on renewable energy for millennia—from burning firewood to harnessing the wind to propel sailing ships. Renewable sources such as sunlight or tidal power are not at all depleted by use. By contrast, fossil fuels—such as coal, oil, and gas—have taken thousands of years to form, and when exhausted, cannot be replaced. Natural gas is an abundant fossil fuel, but its extraction can cause environmental problems, such as earth tremors and water contamination. Nuclear power, although sustainable for a long period of time, is not considered renewable because its production requires a rare type of uranium ore.